

# Play Different

## Will it be innovation or formula for us?

It's all been done, you might say. We've seen enough game genres, sub-genres and styles to make us dizzy. Yet so many games are just variations or corruptions of the same old successful formulae—all first-person shooters after *Half-Life* featured in-game cinematic effects, for instance. Of course, we've seen a lot of new and innovative games since, but the scenario is a little bleak today—rarely do we come across games that light our fires, so to speak.

It's a fiercely competitive industry, this. Add to that the costs—both in time and money—of making a new game, and you've got game studios struggling to make profits. Naturally, sticking to formula is the surest way to success. But there's hope.

### The Quest For Newness

We've probably done a Wii overdose here, but not without reason. Even in the unlikely event that

the Wii vanishes from consciousness in a couple of years, it will have left us with a taste of what it's like to break away from the keyboard + mouse / game controller for interacting with our games—and have us yearning for different, even bizarre, game styles.

And then there's mobility. Mobile games are getting increasingly popular, especially in India and China, and while they won't find much acceptance with hardcore gamers, they will increase the number of casual gamers in the country. When you've got only tiny screens to work with, you tend to focus on making your games fun—small screens don't show off pretty graphics—and the more game developers focus on fun, the more people they'll reel in.

### The Upcoming

It seems that the future belongs to the role-playing game (RPG). The genre has grown around 42 per cent in the last year, and promises to continue along those lines. Not much mystery there—we're sick of linear games that take us in a scripted direction every time, and RPGs offer us freedom to modify our characters, skills, and to some extent, even the story of the game. The trend will be towards more open-ended games that you can play over and over again, using a different approach each time.

*Overlord*, where you play an evil magician on a quest for power, will feature an army of your very own minions, whom you can send into battle against some pesky Halflings, sheep and other such unsuspecting, goodly creatures. The game promises to be as adaptive and engaging as *Black and White*, and may have the same refreshing impact on us.

Another ambitious title is *Splinter Cell: Conviction*. Picking up where *Double Agent* left off, *Conviction* will have you interacting with the environment like never before. You might be able to use a table to shield yourself from enemy fire, for instance, and even break off a leg to use as a club. Developer Ubisoft Montreal wants you to improvise at every step, now that Sam Fisher is a fugitive and doesn't have all his spy gear to help him out.

PCs and consoles aren't the only ones that will benefit, though.

### Gaming Everywhere

With the success of the Nintendo DS and the Sony PSP, we'll be seeing a whole new generation of games for these handheld consoles. Many will evoke nostalgia—imagine playing your favourite old PlayStation games on your PSP, for example. Because the comparatively small screens aren't conducive to long hours of gaming, we'll see more games that offer bite-sized chunks of instant gratification rather than the long, expansive games that we see on PCs and consoles.

Gaming on the go is here to stay, but serious gaming won't go all the way to the mobile phone—specialised devices will always be preferable to all-in-ones, so unless the world likes the idea of a phone the size of a PSP, we'll be buying handheld consoles for our long journeys. ☐

Illustration: Chaitanya's Surpur

